

was reading a film script, looking at the ad storyboard or checking a poster. But I make sure I have the right people to advise me now that the scale is bigger."

Indeed. Kareena has waited eight years to get to a point where she can carry a film, and is now looking for her very own *Erin Brockovich*. She's also smart enough to know not to accept the blank cheques that are sometimes offered to her. "They're a lot of people out there who're ready to make a glamorous Rs 40-crore Kareena Kapoor movie. I've got to be careful. I'd rather work in something like *A Wednesday*," she says. So careful she says that she hasn't had a holiday in a year-and-a-half. "I haven't met my dad in nine months and he's a little upset with me. Even when I'm in Mumbai, where I live with my mother, I get home at 2 a.m. and am out again by 8 a.m. Sleep is a luxury I can't afford." Which is why come December 25, she's going to unplug her phone and take off for a vacation with her family. It's the same with Priyanka, who says sleep is such a waste of time. "I work 18-hour days. I'm lucky I have such an understanding family and friends. They're always dropping by on the sets. And when I'm outdoors, there's nothing more I like than my mom waiting for dinner in the hotel room," she says. Ditto Katrina. "When I'm in Mumbai, the day begins at 7 a.m. and ends at 2 a.m. Outdoor shoots are

BORN TO BLING

Kareena **KAPOOR**, 28

Rs 2.5 crore, seven brands at over Rs 2 crore each

COMING UP *Kambakht Ishq*, where she's a posh princess

“I always had ambition and drive but finally I feel I have proved myself.”



much better, start at 9 a.m. and end at 5 p.m. when the light goes," she says wistfully. But as Rohini Iyer, the head of their agency, Raindrop Media, puts it: "You'll never hear them complaining. They are successful because they are professional. It's not just about looking pretty 20 hours at a stretch."

All of them know Bollywood is still a man's world. Indeed, Katrina owes much of her success to unacknowledged boyfriend Salman Khan who rescued her from her abysmal debut in *Boom*, as well as to Akshay Kumar, with whom she has done four films, and is about to start another, Priyadarshan's *De Dana Dhan*. But Kareena and Priyanka have worked hard to transcend that, taking risks with their career when it mattered. Kareena has survived not only a run-in with Karan Johar, but also a string of flops, while Priyanka has overcome a rather rough time involving a scorned secretary and hero-heavy movies that were wiped out at the box-office.

Knowing the perishable nature of Bollywood heroines, all of them are actively in the learning mode. Priyanka says she's like a sponge dropped in a glass of milk. "I really like to sit with my directors after pack-up, discuss the movie, talk about its marketing." Kareena, whose poise and polish have grown in direct proportion to her relationship with Saif, says work is worship for her. It's the same with Katrina, who's now trying to create a balanced body of work, with experimental and commercial scripts. "The idea is to work with good directors. Of course, I am a single working woman so I have to take care of the finances, but thanks to my endorsements, making money in my movies is not my primary concern." Next year, she hopes she will be able to display some of the much-needed range she has been focusing on.

Rise of the heroine or the death of the hero? Perhaps a bit of both in a year where the script has emerged as the star.